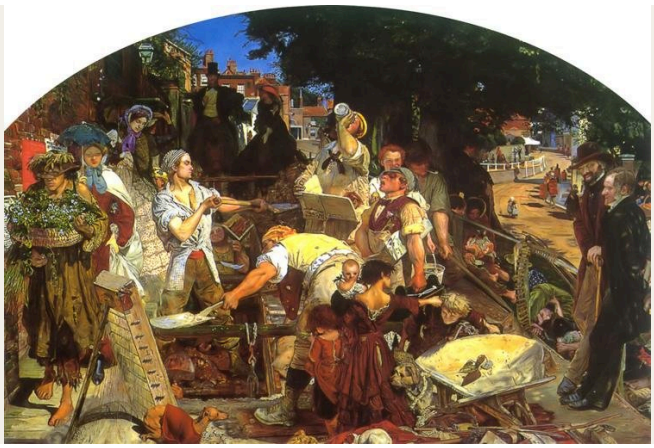
MANCHESTER, UNITED KINGDOM

Manchester Art Gallery: Masterpieces

Twenty paintings that make activity—and its interruption—visible.



The excavation in Ford Madox Brown’s *Work* forces different people into relation. Some dig, others watch or pass, and the street ceases to be a simple route from one place to another. This selection follows that distinction between taking part and standing aside. A shepherd neglects his animals, a family composes a reply to someone overseas, and a woman’s needlework receives the concentrated light often reserved for a public event.

The landscapes extend the question beyond individual bodies. Manchester appears at a distance from greener ground; rivers and fields accommodate trade and labour. These are different arrangements of social life, not illustrations of one uniform moral.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/manchester-art-gallery

The selection · 20

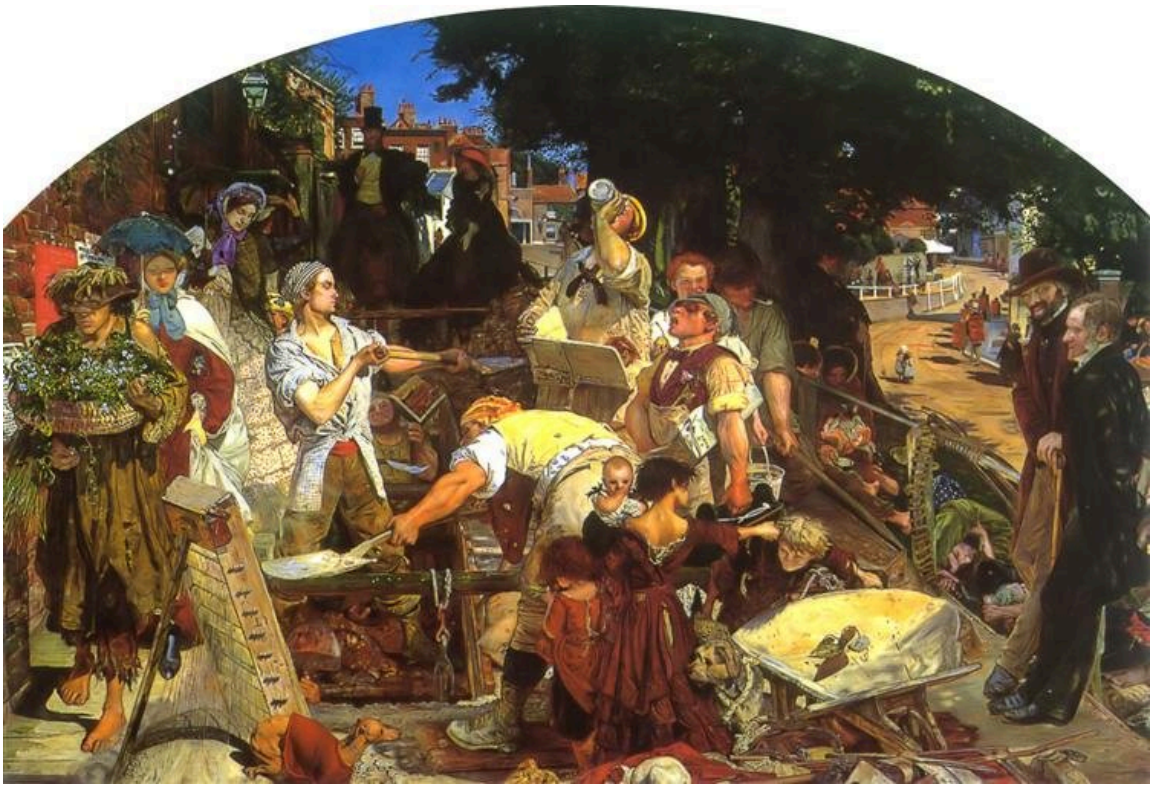
1. Work
   Ford Madox Brown · 1852-1863
2. The Hireling Shepherd
   William Holman Hunt · 1851
3. Hylas and the Nymphs
   John William Waterhouse · 1896
4. Cheetah with Two Indian Servants and a Stag
   George Stubbs · 1765
5. The Dreamer
   Annie Louisa Swynnerton · 1887
6. Italian Girl with Necklace
   Susan Isabel Dacre · 1874–1880
7. Balaclava
   Elizabeth Thompson · 1876
8. Feeding the Ducks
   Edward Stott · 1885
9. Ophelia
   Arthur Hughes · 1852
10. The Death of Arthur
    James Archer · 1860
11. Girl Reading
    Charles Edward Perugini · 1878
12. Answering the Emigrant's Letter
    James Collinson · 1850
13. A Bunch of Thistles
    Rose Magnus · 1896
14. Gathering Plums
    Henry Herbert La Thangue · 1901
15. Chelsea Regatta
    Walter Greaves · 1863–1868
16. Manchester from Belle Vue
    George Danson · 1861
17. View of Manchester from Kersal
    John Barton Waddington · 1856
18. Sweet Industry
    Laura Theresa Alma-Tadema · 1904
19. Grapes
    William Jabez Muckley · 1875
20. Berengaria's Alarm for the Safety of Richard I
    Charles Allston Collins · 1850

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Work

Ford Madox Brown

1852-1863 · Manchester Art Gallery



Ford Madox Brown. Work. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The men digging occupy the street's centre, while other classes and activities gather around the interruption. Brown gives labour a position that passers-by cannot simply ignore. The picture's social argument is inseparable from its congestion: who works, who has time to watch, and who can move on must be read through their placement.

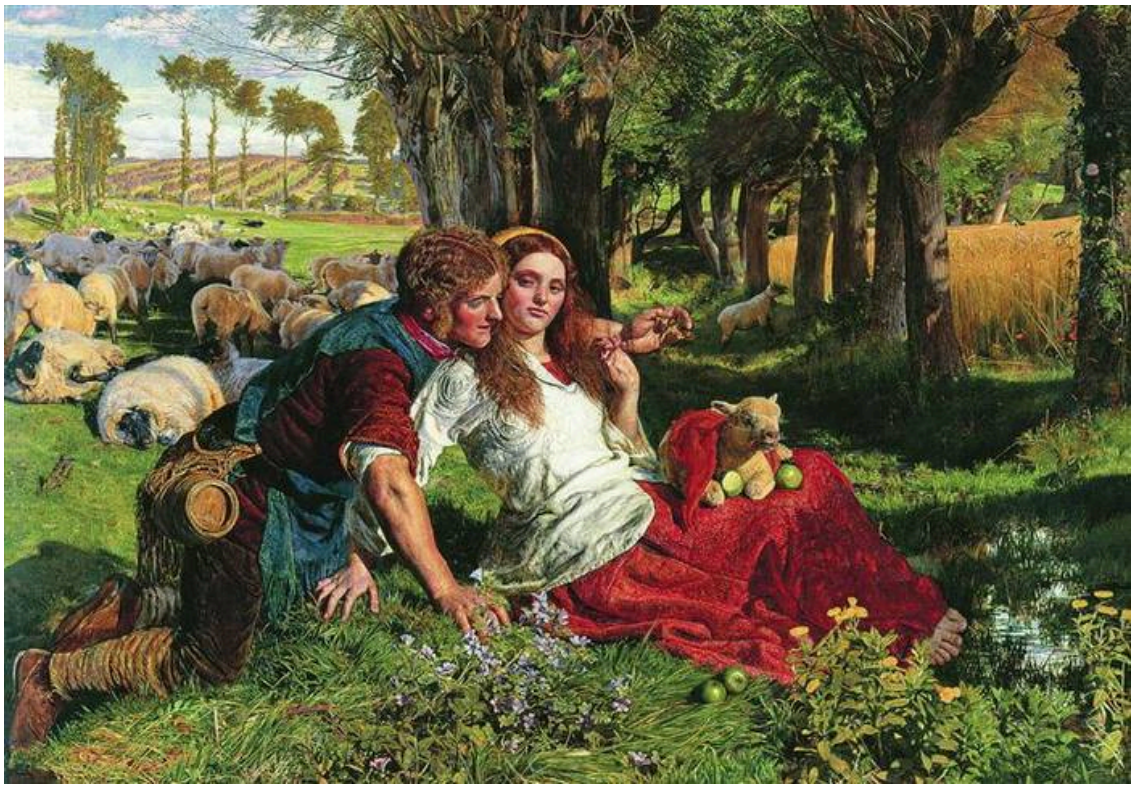
Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

The Hireling Shepherd

William Holman Hunt

1851 · Manchester Art Gallery



William Holman Hunt. The Hireling Shepherd. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The shepherd’s attention follows the woman while the sheep spread behind them. That divided field makes neglect more than an accusation supplied by the title. The foreground encounter has consequences elsewhere in the picture. Hunt asks the spectator to attend to both at once, rather than allowing the close pair to absorb every part of the scene.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Hylas and the Nymphs

John William Waterhouse

1896 · Manchester Art Gallery



John William Waterhouse. Hylas and the Nymphs. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Hylas bends toward the women at the pool, and their reaching hands draw him across a boundary. Pale faces and shoulders are set against dark water, making the apparent invitation especially clear. The myth supplies its danger. The image holds attraction and risk together at the edge where land no longer offers secure footing.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Cheetah with Two Indian Servants and a Stag

George Stubbs

1765 · Manchester Art Gallery



George Stubbs. Cheetah with Two Indian Servants and a Stag. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The attendants' coordinated actions make the cheetah's presence a managed situation. One gestures toward the distant stag, connecting animal observation to the staging of a hunt. Their work should remain visible within a picture often approached principally for Stubbs's animals: the encounter depends on human handling as well as the anatomy of the cat.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

The Dreamer

Annie Louisa Swynnerton

1887 · Manchester Art Gallery



Annie Swynnerton. The Dreamer. Image credit: Annie Swynnerton; Source credit: https://manchesterartgallery.org/explore/title/?mag-object-4412. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The small object and thread suggest an interrupted task, while the woman's face remains directly present. The title invites an inward reading without supplying the thought. Swynnerton leaves those two conditions together: someone occupied with work, and someone whose attention cannot be fully explained by the visible materials in her hands.

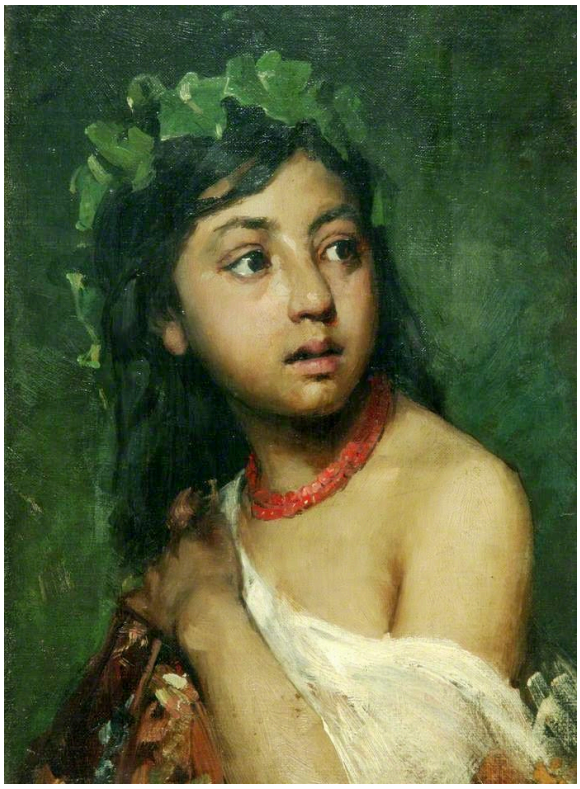
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1936.267

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Italian Girl with Necklace

Susan Isabel Dacre

1874–1880 · Manchester Art Gallery



Susan Isabel Dacre. Italian Girl with Necklace. Image credit: Susan Isabel Dacre; Source credit: figurationfeminine. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The red necklace provides a clear accent against green surroundings and the young woman’s shoulder. Leaves frame the turned head without becoming a separate landscape. The portrait’s economy lies in this limited set of relations: a face, a few adjacent materials and colours strong enough to distinguish them without elaborate scenery.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1884.16

07 / 20

Balaclava

Elizabeth Thompson

1876 · Manchester Art Gallery



Elizabeth Thompson. Balaclava. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The men and horses no longer form a charge. Standing, sitting, exhausted and supported bodies break the group into separate conditions after combat. The comparatively quiet sky offers no equivalent of their disorder. Thompson places military action in its aftermath, where survival and fatigue replace the simple forward direction of an attack.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Feeding the Ducks

Edward Stott

1885 · Manchester Art Gallery



Edward Stott. Feeding the Ducks. Image credit: Edward Stott; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The bowl joins the girl's lowered attention to the approaching ducks. A small exchange becomes sufficient to organise the water's edge, tree and reflections around it. There is no need for a dramatic gesture: the birds' gathering supplies a response to the figure's task and gives the quiet scene its action.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1947.72

09 / 20

Ophelia

Arthur Hughes

1852 · Manchester Art Gallery



Arthur Hughes. Ophelia. Image credit: Arthur Hughes; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The arched upper edge helps enclose a seated Ophelia within plants beside the water. Her raised hand and pale dress keep attention on a suspended bodily position. This is not the floating corpse familiar from Millais. Hughes holds the figure on the bank, leaving the event associated with her name outside the depicted moment.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1955.105

10 / 20

The Death of Arthur

James Archer

1860 · Manchester Art Gallery



James Archer. La mort d'Arthur. Image credit: James Archer; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The armoured body requires attendance from the surrounding women. Their positions organise a scene in which the principal figure can no longer act. Beyond them, the waiting boat gives the shore a direction of departure. The legend’s ending is presented through care for a body and preparation for what happens next.

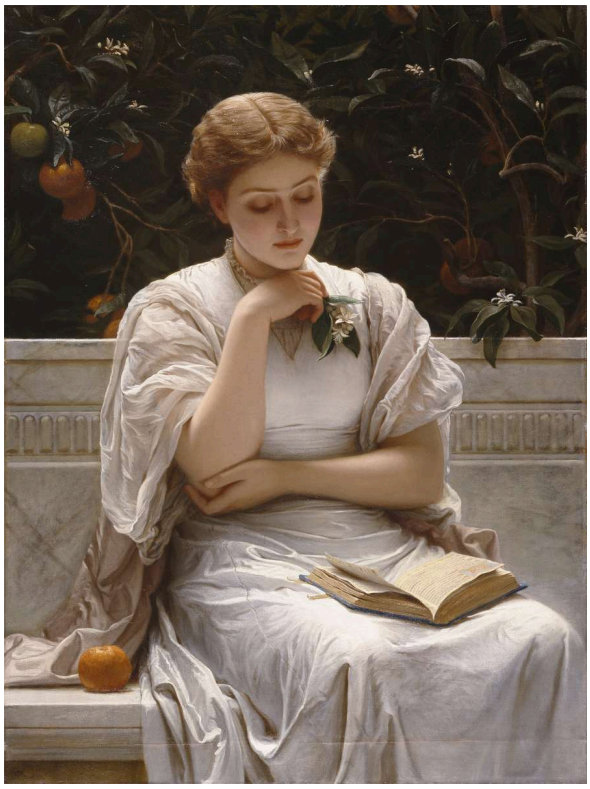
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1952.252

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Girl Reading

Charles Edward Perugini

1878 · Manchester Art Gallery



Charles Edward Perugini. Girl Reading. Image credit: Charles Edward Perugini; Source credit: https://manchesterartgallery.org/explore/title/?mag-object-734. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The open book remains on the lap while one hand supports the chin. Reading is present, but so is the bodily pause around it. Dark foliage makes the pale figure clear without supplying an explanation for her thoughts. Perugini gives an ordinary adjustment of posture enough attention to become the picture’s main event.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1917.237

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Answering the Emigrant’s Letter

James Collinson

1850 · Manchester Art Gallery



James Collinson. Answering the Emigrant's Letter. Image credit: James Collinson; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The emigrant is absent, but the letter gathers a household around the work of replying. Different people share a table and attend to one sheet. Distance is therefore made visible through its effect on those who remain at home: communication becomes a collective effort rather than a private exchange between two isolated individuals.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1966.179

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A Bunch of Thistles

Rose Magnus

1896 · Manchester Art Gallery



Rose Magnus. A Bunch of Thistles. Image credit: Rose Magnus; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The thistles retain their pointed leaves and uneven heads rather than being smoothed into an ideal bouquet. A simple vessel and plain ground leave that irregularity room. The painting’s structure follows the plant’s difficult outlines, giving something prickly and commonplace the sustained attention usually associated with more accommodating flowers.

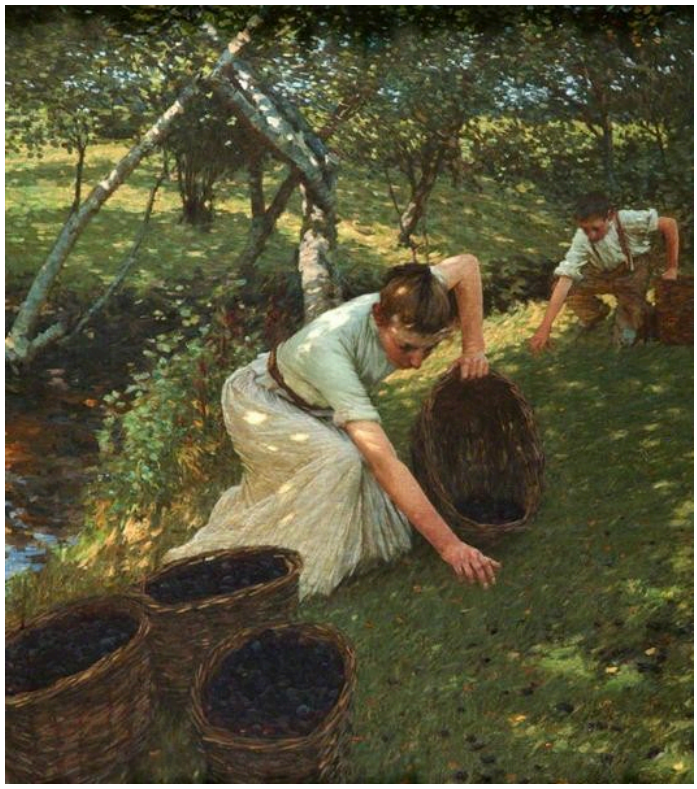
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1936.241

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Gathering Plums

Henry Herbert La Thangue

1901 · Manchester Art Gallery



Henry Herbert La Thangue. Gathering Plums. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

One figure bends close to the ground while another continues the harvest farther back. Repeated changes of posture connect the foreground task to a larger area beneath the trees. The basket gives the labour a practical destination, keeping the sunlit scene attached to the effort of gathering rather than mere enjoyment of the orchard.

Object source · Open artwork

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Chelsea Regatta

Walter Greaves

1863–1868 · Manchester Art Gallery



Walter Greaves. Chelsea Regatta. Image credit: Walter Greaves; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Boats, shore and buildings offer different positions from which to participate in the regatta. No single spectator accounts for its scale. Greaves accumulates small incidents around the shared river, allowing the event to spread across places occupied in different ways instead of reducing it to one decisive boat race.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1922.8

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Manchester from Belle Vue

George Danson

1861 · Manchester Art Gallery



George Danson. Manchester from Belle Vue. Image credit: George Danson; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Factories and smoke belong to the distant city, with people and animals on greener ground nearer the spectator. The separation makes urban growth a relationship between environments rather than a view composed only of buildings. Distance does important work: it permits the industrial area to be seen as an extent within a larger landscape.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1947.328

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View of Manchester from Kersal

John Barton Waddington

1856 · Manchester Art Gallery



John Barton Waddington. View of Manchester from Kersal. Image credit: John Barton Waddington; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The elevated position gives an account of Manchester's spread along the river. Chimneys and large buildings emerge through haze beyond comparatively open ground. That foreground is a measure as well as a setting: the city's occupation of the distant landscape becomes more legible because the near land is less densely built.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1927.42

18 / 20

Sweet Industry

Laura Theresa Alma-Tadema

1904 · Manchester Art Gallery



Laura Theresa Alma-Tadema. Sweet Industry. Image credit: Laura Theresa Alma-Tadema; Source credit: Manchester Art Gallery , image. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The illuminated hands and needlework give the dark room a small working centre. The woman’s pink dress remains part of that contained situation rather than a public display. Alma-Tadema allows skill to appear through concentration and a limited gesture, without expanding the domestic task into a theatrical performance.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1904.13

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Grapes

William Jabez Muckley

1875 · Manchester Art Gallery



William Jabez Muckley. Grapes. Image credit: William Jabez Muckley; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Glass, grapes, fabric and the patterned dish are packed closely, yet each remains distinguishable. Reflections and changes in translucency do work that wider gaps might otherwise perform. Muckley makes material differences the still life's organising principle: the same light cannot produce the same surface on every object.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1936.120

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Berengaria’s Alarm for the Safety of Richard I

Charles Allston Collins

1850 · Manchester Art Gallery



Charles Allston Collins. Berengaria's Alarm for the Safety of Her Husband, Richard Coeur de Lion, Awakened by the Sight of His Girdle Offered for Sale at Rome. Image credit: Charles Allston Collins; Source credit: scan of painting. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The visitor’s displayed object changes how people attend to one another. Berengaria rises, and the surrounding figures turn toward the exchange. The historical narrative reaches the room through something small enough to be shown in a hand. Recognition is distributed through gestures before it becomes a fully stated account of the news.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1896.1

Begin with a kind of attention

Work, *Sweet Industry* and *Answering the Emigrant’s Letter* make a useful trio: public labour, domestic skill and the work of maintaining a distant relationship. Compare how each gives its task a centre. This selection includes collection holdings rather than a confirmed hanging; consult the gallery for current availability.

Further reading

The Elements of Drawing

John Ruskin · Read free · English

Ruskin’s attention to close observation accompanies the Pre-Raphaelite works and several studies of plants and ordinary materials. His exercises offer a way of examining their details without treating every object as a symbol.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

Artline · Manchester Art Gallery: Masterpieces